

Recession woes

Nokia, the world's largest mobile phone maker, said its profits plummeted 90 per cent in the first quarter of 2009 due to fading demand for mobile phones amid the worldwide downturn

ASUS P565

In terms of looks, although it's nearly the same dimensions as the P552W, the P565 is a world apart in terms of pedigree. The fascia is finished in glossy black, ditto the buttons. The rear and sides are finished in matte silver plastic while the battery cover has a faux-leather finish. The screen is much better than the screen on the P552w and really the difference is akin to night and day. Once again, the quick launch button is a really a quick way to access the most commonly used settings and menus and not just a cosmetic addition. The two-way volume button is short in length, but works well because it's really soft and wide enough to easily contact the pad of your finger, unlike some of the other phones that have very thin, long rocker buttons for volume control. Although the phone is microSD expandable and states it's hot-swappable, the battery has to be removed in order to access the memory tray slot making the term "hot swappable" something of a joke.

Although ASUS claims that the phone is powered by an 800 MHz CPU; the said processor is a Marvell TavorP that while rated at a clock of 800 MHz isn't the fastest around; evident from the interface. This is the same family of CPU running on the Blackberry Bold, albeit at a slower speed. It's a single chip solution that combines an HSDPA baseband processor with a general processor. It is a low-cost solution and may not be as fast as devices with discrete application processors. That being said, the P565 is no slouch.

Its performance in the call-based tests was better than the P552w, but marginally so. It performed adequately, on the whole. Audio quality of the handsfree unit is much better, as is the loudspeaker, although

it's anything but loud. Priced at Rs. 21,900 the P565 is a decent offering with classy looks and performance, that while not excellent, is passable. Had ASUS thrown in a hardware QWERTY this would make for a sweet buy.

Boardroom buddies Business phones above Rs. 25,000

Nokia E75

At first glance, the Nokia E75 is a stunner, although its sibling the E71 may look a more serious corporate device. Its got a mix of gray, silver and chrome and is built very well, although not as well as the E71. For Nokia, the E75 is one of their first phones that charges from USB; although the standard Nokia charger port is also provided. The screen is 2.4-inches diagonally and is clear and crisp. The number keypad is neat and the keys well laid, offering good feedback and usability. At first, the phone seems a little heavy then we discovered the side-sliding QWERTY. This keypad has matte rubber finished keys but the first flaw was the total lack of any bevelling. While the keys are very large there is no spacing between them and this is the second problem; having keys too close to each other only works if they are bevelled and without this it's an ergonomic nightmare. There's a slight divide in the middle of the keypad that also breaks the continuous flow of keys. The joypad is not as good as the one on the N95 8 GB and the menu and call accept/reject buttons have been moved on to a single long two-way rocker button. The buttons on the sides of the phone are identical to the Nokia E71. Once again we feel Nokia wasted some space above the screen and

2.4-inches is just not enough, we'd love a larger screen, something like the screen on the N95 8GB.

The camera despite its 3.2 MP rating isn't as crisp as we'd like and most images have some sort of graininess. Like some of the higher end 6-series phones the E75 features a TV-out. It also has a rather small 1,000 mAh battery. A neat plus is the 3.5-mm jack that allows use of other headphones. The camera button is tiny and hard to press – though this isn't

as important for a business phone. In-call quality is good, really good and this phone has a good antenna, although by Nokia's high standards set

with devices like the N96 and the N95 8 GB this one seems fairly mediocre.

The bundled handsfree unit is good, but a 3.5-mm connect other headphones can also be used. Priced at Rs. 26,299, the E75 is a really feature-rich phone that offers something for nearly everyone. It's just that it doesn't focus on one cadre of users over others – the phrase *Jack of all trades* comes to mind. The E71 is a better business phone because of its smarter keypad, and obviously the lower price tag, with marginally better performance.

HTC Touch Pro

The HTC Touch Pro is a bulky, thick phone that is built a lot like the HTC Touch Diamond, except that it sports a more rugged matte finish rather than the smooth finish on the latter. The 2.8-inch screen is crisp and clear with a high resolution of 480 x 640 pixels and this phone is even heavier than the Touch HD, whose screen is a whole inch bigger. The reason for its weight and the bulkiness is a full-QWERTY keypad hidden inside a side-slider. At 165 grams it was

the heaviest phone in the entire test. Although the slide-out mechanism is quite snappy the build quality may be a bit iffy since we noticed some play after heavy usage. The interface is similar to the Touch HD although the phone is nowhere as responsive, especially when using the Touch Flo feature. The QWERTY scores big points for having a well laid out keypad, with big buttons that exude positive feedback and are really well backlit, good enough for usage in daylight and darkness alike. The keys are largely flat with just a hint of bevelling on the top and this is the most usable QWERTY keypad after the Blackberry devices. When we opened the back we discovered the reason behind the thickness which was not entirely the keypads fault but was on account of the really thick battery pack. The front menu buttons and joypad are identical to the Touch Diamond.

The camera outputs decent images. Unfortunately HTC traded the 3.5-mm jack for a proprietary USB based headset – zero points for convenience. Signal quality was mediocre, bordering on poor, in zone 2 and we lament the lack of a better antenna unit like the Touch HD's. Priced at Rs. 32,990 we feel the Touch Pro a bit too expensive for the features and performance on offer, it does have an excellent keypad and would be a decent choice for someone wanting a Windows Mobile-based PDA with a full keypad, although to be honest, we'd suggest the all-round capabilities of the Sony Ericsson Xperia X1 in such case.

BEST BUY
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Nokia E75



ASUS P565



HTC Touch Pro